

HISTORY HACK • DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Analyze the following three primary source excerpts and write a document-based essay that argues whether the policy of appeasement and American isolationism made World War II inevitable.

US.47 — Explain the rise and spread of fascism, communism, and totalitarianism internationally, including the following leaders: • Adolf Hitler • Benito Mussolini • Joseph Stalin • Hideki Tojo

US.48 — Explain the progression of key events and President Franklin D. Roosevelt’s response to world crises that lead to U.S. entry into World War II, including the Quarantine Speech, the Four Freedoms Speech, the Atlantic Charter, the Lend-Lease Act, and Pearl Harbor.

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

The sources

Document A

Excerpt from the Atlantic Charter, signed by FDR and Winston Churchill, August 14, 1941 (National Archives, public domain)

“First, their countries seek no aggrandizement, territorial or other; Second, they desire to see no territorial changes that do not accord with the freely expressed wishes of the peoples concerned; Third, they respect the right of all peoples to choose the form of government under which they will live...”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Excerpt from the Neutrality Act of 1937, U.S. Congress (Avalon Project, Yale Law School, public domain)

“Whenever the President shall find that there exists a state of war between, or among, two or more foreign states, the President shall proclaim such fact, and it shall thereafter be unlawful to export, or attempt to export, or cause to be exported, arms, ammunition, or implements of war from any place in the United States to any belligerent state...”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document C

Excerpt from FDR's 'Arsenal of Democracy' Fireside Chat, December 29, 1940 (Franklin D. Roosevelt Presidential Library; public domain government record)

“The Nazi masters of Germany have made it clear that they intend not only to dominate all life and thought in their own country, but also to enslave the whole of Europe, and then to use the resources of Europe to dominate the rest of the world... If Great Britain goes down, the Axis powers will control the continents of Europe, Asia, Africa... and they will be in a position to bring enormous military and naval resources against this hemisphere.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using HIPP (Historical context, Intended audience, Purpose, Point of view) analysis for each document and your knowledge of U.S. foreign policy from 1935 to 1941, construct an argument that evaluates the relationship between American isolationism, the failure of international response to fascist aggression, and the conditions that made a global war both predictable and avoidable. Address how FDR's evolving rhetoric in Documents A and C contrasts with the formal neutrality of Document B.

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Sophisticated historically defensible thesis. All three documents analyzed using HIPP with accuracy — historical context, audience, purpose, and point of view for each. At least three pieces of outside evidence (beyond the documents). Demonstrates why isolationism enabled aggression AND engages with the counterargument (could war have been avoided). Synthesizes across all documents and outside knowledge. Writing is organized, precise, and historically specific.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. All three documents analyzed with at least three HIPP elements each. Two pieces of outside evidence. Addresses the tension between documents A/C and B. Mostly organized.
4	Proficient. Clear thesis. Two documents analyzed with HIPP. One to two pieces of outside evidence. Argument present but some analytical gaps. Organized.
3	Adequate. Thesis present but vague. One to two documents analyzed, HIPP partially applied. One piece of outside evidence. Argument partially developed.
2	Developing. Minimal thesis. Documents described but not analyzed. Little outside evidence. Argument not fully developed.
1	Beginning. No thesis or off-topic thesis. One document mentioned. No HIPP analysis. No outside evidence.
0	No response or completely off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: Doc A — HIPP reveals FDR's ideological commitment to democratic principles before formal war entry; Doc B — HIPP reveals domestic political constraints on executive action; Doc C — HIPP reveals FDR's rhetorical strategy of strategic self-interest argument (not idealism) to shift isolationist public. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: Munich Agreement (September 1938); Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact (August 1939); German invasion of Poland (September 1939); Fall of France (June 1940); Lend-Lease Act (March 1941); America First Committee; Pearl Harbor (December 1941).

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.